

view it has so much to do with our current and future financial success. Student loans, car payments, mortgages, small business start-up loans; they can all help us or hurt us. Borrowing is what allows us to go to college when we have time in our twenties, rather than needing to wait until our fifties to afford a bachelor's degree out of pocket. Borrowing is what allows us to get into a safe home while the kids are young, instead of waiting until they're grown to get a roof over their heads. Borrowing is what allowed me to get a vehicle that was safe to drive, instead of the rusting SUV we had with brake lines that went out on us three times in one month. Debt can be a tool. Debt can be debilitating. But ultimately debt is neutral.

For our friend Jamie, this perspective has been a game-changer when it comes to how she thinks and feels about her student loan debt. She graduated from a private university with \$87,000 of debt and is still working to pay this off. Even before graduation there were nights she laid awake thinking about the money she was soon to owe. For her, this concept of debt being neutral is what shifted her thoughts about the decisions she made in her education. Whenever she experiences anxiety, or even guilt, about her student loan debt, Jamie works to remind herself that her education was worth investing in. That she is worth investing in. While there are parts of her that wishes she chose a less expensive university, or applied for more scholarships, she's embracing the path she's on and taking reasonable steps to pay down her debt while still living her life. Having a plan in place and following through on that plan is what's helping her tackle the debt, without the debt taking over her life. It's her mindset that has been making the biggest difference in the way she thinks about herself and the permission she has found to still enjoy the things money can't buy (and a few of the things it can!). Jamie's also recognizing that even in debt's neutrality she can experience peace of mind, freedom in spending decisions, greater financial margin to save and invest, and better credit scores for future mindful borrowing if she does pay off her debt. *Especially* high interest debt.

For some of us, debt can feel like an awful chain around our neck when it costs us exponentially more than the amount borrowed due to soaring interest rates. For some of us, it feels like a wealth-building tool.

Contentment doesn't mean complacency with the debt we carry. Contentment encourages us to pay it off in a way that aligns with affording what we love and embracing our season. When people ask us about paying